

Online Photo Album Services at a Glance

Service	Storage Size	Photo Scanning Services	Direct Links to Albums	Cost Per Print	Pros and Cons	Overall Rating
DotPhoto	Unlimited	Yes	Yes	4x6 inch: \$0.29 (~ Rs 14) 5x7 inch: \$0.95 (~ Rs 47) 8x10 inch: \$2.95 (~ Rs 147) 12x18 inch: \$9.99 (~ Rs 500)	+ Order 30 free prints! Bulk prints are really cheap - Slow upload speeds, cumbersome navigation	★★★★☆
Kodak Picture Center	Free hosting for 200 photos for 6 months	Yes	Yes	4x6 inch: \$0.24 (~ Rs 12) 5x7 inch: \$0.89 (~ Rs 44) 8x10 inch: \$2.59 (~ Rs 130)	+ Ties up with retail photo processing giants worldwide - Images are viewable only as thumbnails	★★★★☆
MSN Communities	30 MB	No	Yes	No Printing Facility	+ No registration required, ties with MSN services - No facility for printing photos	★★★★☆
Ofoto	Unlimited	Yes	Yes	4x6 inch: \$0.49 (~ Rs 24) 5x7 inch: \$0.99 (~ Rs 50) 8x10 inch: \$3.99 (~ Rs 200)	+ Easy to use and quick uploading - Expensive shipping rates	★★★★★
Photo Jagat	Unlimited	No	No	4x6 inch: \$0.35 (~ Rs 17)	+ Provides printing services in India - A tad on the expensive side	★★★★☆
Shutterfly	NA	Yes	Yes	4x6 inch: \$0.49 (~ Rs 24) 5x7 inch: \$0.99 (~ Rs 50) 8x10 inch: \$3.99 (~ Rs 200)	+ Easy to use, 15 free prints - Expensive shipping rates	★★★★★
Yahoo! Photos	30 MB	Yes	No	Prints developed at Shutterfly at the same price	+ Very convenient, easy to use and maintain - Outhouse processing, ordering prints is cumbersome	★★★★☆

cumbersome and only one can be uploaded at a time. The gallery interface only lets you see small samples of the image. This service ties up with many retail photo development giants around the world, which provide professional scanning and delivery services.

www.picturecenter.kodak.com

MSN Groups: Microsoft's community Web site, *MSN Groups*, allows you to start your own e-group where you can share up to 30 MB of images. This service is only oriented towards viewing and sharing your pictures, and ties up well with a host of other MSN services like the chat and e-mail clients.

www.communities.msn.com

Ofoto: This site has a drag-and-drop desktop software called Ofotonow that makes uploading photos extremely easy. It automatically transfers photos from your camera, allows for photo editing and lets you order prints through a single click. You can frame photos, create cards and more. Ofoto sends the prints to anywhere in the world through Federal Express shipments. The prices of the prints are reasonable, but the cost of shipping will pinch your wallet. They charge \$0.98 (approx Rs 49) for two 4x6 photos and \$4.99 (approx Rs 250) for shipping them! Payments can be made only by international credit cards such as Visa, Mastercard, American Express, etc.

www.ofoto.com



Photo Jagat: This site has all the required features and a helpful support and FAQ section. It recommends the best size for prints depending on the quality of your images. It has a client called PC Uploader that allows bulk uploading of images directly from your desktop. The main advantage with Photo Jagat is that it allows you to send prints within India using Speedpost and DTDC. It still requires an international credit card and at 35 cents a print (approx Rs 17), isn't the cheapest service around.

www.photojagat.com



Shutterfly: Shutterfly allows you to add, enhance, share and order prints online, and promises film-quality prints delivered to your doorstep. It also provides services for film processing from analogue cameras and uploading them online, and has features to create greeting cards from your photos. Shutterfly has a picture upload plugin that makes it easy to transfer pictures to your photo gallery from your desktop. The first 15 prints are provided free of cost, which means that you only have to pay for the shipping.

www.shutterfly.com



Yahoo! Photos: This is a totally free service provided by *Yahoo!* for all its users. All you need is a *Yahoo!* account and you're set. Uploading is manual and the site is fully functional in a no-frills kind of way. You can order prints, mugs, T-shirts and greeting cards customised with your photos, and the site

ties in with other *Yahoo!* community services pretty well. It doesn't offer print processing, but redirects you to Shutterfly instead, where you can order prints. The main disadvantage here is that the site does not list India for photo print delivery.

<http://photos.yahoo.com>

Photo finish

Using an online photo album opens up your personal life to the entire world. Sharing your pictures for everyone to see on the World Wide Web just might turn into an open invitation for stalkers, spammers and the like. It's a better idea to create password-protected albums. Most photo album sites have an option for keeping the albums either public or password protected.

Although there is no dearth of Web sites offering free online photo albums, there is a wide variation in their reliability and the features offered. Some seem to offer you everything—full size images, nice thumbnails, good design, etc—and then they shut down, leaving you tearing your hair out: *ecircles.com* and *zing.com* were one of the first of such services but now no longer exist. Therefore, it would make sense to keep backups of your pictures on your PC and not rely on these services alone. Yet, with the functionality and universal appeal that these services provide, they are the best choice for shutterbugs who need a platform for displaying snapshots of their memories. So go ahead and use the Web as your photo gallery. ■

SIRIRAM SHARMA